



shot image and apply corrective measures to fix its attributes like brightness, contrast, red-eye reduction, gamma levels, etc. Compare the quality of prints taken with your printer's autofix feature enabled against the photos when it was disabled and see for yourself which effect you like the most.

Printing via third-party photo software

Earlier in the article we highlighted the importance of printing directly via a camera's SD card or applying a one-click auto-fix to correct your images before printing them. In an opposite tangent, we also recommend the use of third-party photo tools which can go a long way in enhancing your printed photos quality.

Professional tools like Adobe Photoshop or GIMP are excellent for determining and controlling every minute attribute of a photo. They offer great depth in manipulating and controlling even the smallest aspect of a photo, therefore letting you have the prints you desire to the T. In this case, the features and degree of manipulation offered by these advanced photo editing tools far exceeds the simple, one-click auto-fix solution built into the printers. Even Google Picasa and Irfanview let you tweak and edit your image to a certain degree, and there's no harm in investing some time in them. If you're looking at

an online photo editor, Pixlr is one of the best we've come across. In your quest towards printing great quality photos, you should definitely dedicate some time to learning the ropes of a photo software.

GOOGLE EARTH

Google Earth is a free software which allows you to explore detailed aerial photos and satellite imagery of planet Earth. Google Earth is easy to use and consists of both professional and community-based contributions. It is undisputedly the best free mapping software available today.

Learn mouse gestures for easy navigation

Google Earth is fairly easy to navigate on a laptop trackpad but using a mouse with a scroll-wheel makes a whole world of difference. Navigating with a scroll-wheel allows for quick and controlled zooming in and zooming out. Also, holding down the scroll-wheel button lets you tilt the world around, and holding down the right-mouse button turns your mouse into a virtual joystick which lets you freely zoom-in and out with ease.

Adjust orientation to due north

If you went overboard with the mouse and now your worlds all messed up and upside-



The Wikipedia icon appears as a white box with a black W

down, simply clicking on the N in navigation controls will set you right. Just pressing the [N] key on the keyboard works just as well.

Go back in time

The Historical Imagery button, i.e. the clock button in the toolbar allows you to turn back time and take a look at what Earth used to look like. This gives you a slider which you can adjust to view images of the Earth dating back to the 1930's. This is especially handy if you want to compare images of Earth before and after major events occurred in the past.

Zoom Smoother

Victims of slow internet connections and weak machines will find that quickly zooming-in and out is laggy and the imagery takes forever to process, an issue faced by many. In this case, it might be a good idea to go ahead and increase the cache size of stored images. At the cost of using more of your memory/hard disk space, zooming is considerably faster and smoother. This also improves the speed at which layers load, including 3D models. The cache size can be increased by accessing the Tools menu and then selecting Options... and selecting the Cache tab.

Set a starting location

The Earth is pretty big, and it's easy to get lost exploring it. It happens to the best of us, and nobody blames you. So, if you do find yourself lost with no clue as to where you are, simply double-click on the Primary Database in the layers section. This automatically sets you to O N O E, which is Google Earth's default starting location.

Additionally, you can set your own starting location. After setting the view that you want when you open Google Earth, the 'Make this my start location' option in the View menu will place a marker called Starting Location which can be found under My Places. Double-clicking this marker will return you to your start location.

Use Google Earth for Research

Google Earth has many layers devoted exclusively to science and information. Additionally, under the More Layers sub-menu, the Wikipedia layer can be turned on at any time. This provides users with a short Wikipedia article related to the specified location. Furthermore, under the Photos Layer sub-menu, 360cities is an interesting layer which takes users



An app like Pixlr has some interesting options for you to try